

ABEKA SCHOLAR ACADEMY

Subj Grade 2 Bible Stories Curriculum

Official Curriculum & Study Material

Chapter 1

Welcome to our amazing journey into bible stories! We have so many fun things to discover today. Let's get started! Did you know? The Bible, also known as the Holy Bible, is a group of religious texts central to Judaism and Christianity. The Christian Bible contains both the Old Testament and the New Testament. It is the best-selling book in the world. Three quarters of the Christian Bible is the same as the Hebrew Bible used in Judaism. Many Christians and Jews believe that the Bible is the word of God. The Bible is divided into books. In fact, the word "Bible" comes from the Greek word βιβλία (biblia) which means "books" in English. Some books are texts that may have been written or collected by one person. The book may be named for that person. Other books include the writings of several different people.

Let me tell you a fascinating story. The books of the Bible focus on various subjects, including: The history of the first humans, the Jews, Jesus, and his followers Did you know? God's commands to his people, which he expects them to obey

Teaching about and how the death and resurrection of Jesus brought salvation Close your eyes and picture this... Prophecy (The Bible says these are messages from God that tell about future events. These were given through chosen people called prophets .) Not all groups of Christians agree on which texts should be included in the Bible. Christian Bibles range from the 66 books of the Protestant canon to 81 books in the Ethiopian Orthodox Bible.

Did you know? The oldest surviving Christian Bible is the Codex Sinaiticus, a Greek manuscript from the fourth century AD. Until recently, the oldest complete Hebrew manuscripts were from the Middle Ages. However, the Dead Sea scrolls contain some of the Hebrew books and were written between 300 BCE and 100 CE. The Bible was written long ago in Aramaic, Hebrew, and Greek. Before that, people passed its earliest stories from generation to generation through oral tradition: by word of mouth. After the Bible was translated into Latin and other languages, it became easier for people to share the written Bible. Now there are translations in English, Simple English, and hundreds of other languages. The books of the Hebrew Bible—what Christians call the Old Testament—were written at different times during the course of about 1200 years. The Hebrew people began to put all of these books together around 400 B.C.

Five hundred years later, around 100 A.D., believers began to collect the books of the New Testament.

Originally written in Greek, it tells about things that happened between 4 B.C. and 70 A.D. It tells the stories of Jesus's birth, life, death, and resurrection. It describes how Jesus's followers went around spreading his message. It ends with a description of how the world will end when Jesus returns to earth. Believers say that most of the New Testament was written by Jesus's apostles. These were people who said they had seen Jesus alive after his crucifixion. There is not one single version of the Bible; both the content of the books and their order may change. Followers of Judaism and Christianity consider the Bible sacred, but they do not all agree about what belongs in it. Different denominations include certain parts or leave out other parts. Before the invention of printing, some changes came into the hand copied texts. Studying the oldest copies shows that these are very minor. Translations also vary because languages do not match up exactly. Translators have to decide between translating things word for word, or using different words to capture the sense of the text.

Chapter 2

In the 4th century, a Gothic bishop named Ulfilas (Wulfila) translated the Bible into the Gothic language. Did you know? In the early 5th century, Saint Jerome created an important Latin version of the Bible called the Vulgate. Later, in the early Middle Ages, people like Petrus Valdes and Jan Hus provided translations. The New Testament was first translated into English in 1382 by John Wycliffe. (His associates translated the Old Testament.) He used the Vulgate Bible for his translation, which he wrote in Middle English, the language of his day. Wycliffe wanted to translate the Bible into common language so that people could see for themselves what it said. He did not have the Church's permission to do this, but he was protected by John of Gaunt, one of the most powerful men in the kingdom.

After Wycliffe and John of Gaunt were both dead, in 1415, the Church declared Wycliffe a heretic and banned his writings. Wycliffe's translations challenged the Church's authority over the people. In church, explaining the Bible was the priest's work. Whatever he said could not be challenged. But if ordinary people could read the Bible, they might have other opinions. The Council of Constance decreed that Wycliffe's works should be burned and his remains exhumed (dug up). In 1525, William Tyndale translated the Bible into Early Modern English, which we can just about understand today. Like Wycliffe, Tyndale wrote his translation without the Church's permission. His was the first translation to be printed, and several thousand copies were made. Without any protector, Tyndale fled to Europe, but agents of Thomas More (the Chancellor of England) eventually found him. Both

Tyndale and his printer were executed by burning at the stake. The Catholic Church published an English translation called the Douay Rheims Bible with the New Testament in 1582 and the Old in 1609. It was translated from the Latin Vulgate.

Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! Another well-known translation is the 1611 King James translation (commonly known as the Authorized King James Version of the Bible). Today there are hundreds of versions of the Bible. Some are more literal (word for word) translations, while others use modern ways of speaking to give the same meaning. Modern versions are based on the oldest Greek and Hebrew copies, and translators can also check other ancient versions. Because we have thousands of very old copies of the Bible, modern translations are closer to the original text than ever before. As of December 2025, the complete version of the Bible existed in 784 languages, while parts of the Bible have been translated into 3294 languages. Let me tell you a fascinating story. In its various versions the Bible is the best-selling book of all time. By 2025, between 5 billion and 6 billion copies have been sold.

The Old Testament is the first 39 books of the Christian Bible (which has 66 books overall). It tells the first part of God's story of salvation. According to the Bible, "salvation" is God's long work of saving us from our sins. It says that people sin when they decide to live their own way instead of God's way in the world that God created. The Old Testament tells the story of Noah's Ark, in which God sent a great flood to destroy the whole world in order to prepare the way for salvation. He saved only the family of Noah, then raised up a new people for himself. Among them were the ancient Hebrews. God promised the Hebrews they would bring his salvation to the whole world. The first five books of the Old Testament mostly tell the story of how God chose the ancient Hebrews and taught them his laws. The next twelve books tell the history of the Hebrews. The following five are books of poetry and wisdom. One of these, the "Psalms", is a book of songs showing mainly how God wants to be worshiped.

The last seventeen books of the Old Testament were written by Hebrew prophets. These books tell about God's disappointment with the ancient Hebrews and his promise to bring them back to friendship with him. The prophets also foretell that God will send his son to earth in order to save humanity from their sins. In the Old Testament, Tanakh was mostly written in Hebrew; a few parts were written in Aramaic. This part of the Bible is considered to be holy by Jews as well as Christians. There are also a few books of the Old Testament's time called Deuterocanonical by those Churches that accept them as part of the Bible, and Apocrypha by those that do not.

Chapter 3

Here's a really cool secret about this topic: The second part of the Bible is called the New Testament. It begins with four books about the life of Jesus. These four books, called Gospels, tell about the three years when Jesus was teaching and doing miracles and healing people. They tell a lot about his death and resurrection. The first three gospels, Matthew, Mark and Luke are very similar. The fourth gospel, John, includes many additional things Jesus said. One of the most quoted verses in the Bible is John 3:16: "For God so loved the world that He gave His one and only Son, that whoever believes in Him shall not perish [die] but have eternal life." NIV Here's a really cool secret about this topic: After the Gospels, the New Testament tells the story of what happened to the Church after Jesus's death and resurrection. There is in a history called the Acts of the Apostles. Letters written by early Christian leaders, especially Saint Paul, help to record how belief in Jesus spread. They also tell how the death and resurrection of Jesus bring forgiveness and a new life. They instruct the Christians what to believe and how to live. Here's a really cool secret about this topic: The final book of the Bible tells about a vision experienced by St. John, one of Jesus's disciples. In the vision, John saw what would happen at the end of the world. This included judgement for evil and happiness for the people who had followed Jesus.

Here's a really cool secret about this topic: People have different ideas about the Bible. Protestants and Catholics believe that the Old and New Testaments are God's Word. Jews believe that only the Old Testament is from God. Catholics also believe that the books called Deuterocanonical are part of the Bible. Sometimes different denominations disagree over exactly what the Bible means. Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! Deists believe in God; however, they believe the Bible was written by people rather than God, and view it as unimportant. Let me tell you a fascinating story. *Entre Galilée et l'Église : la Bible., Une mise au point. Étude.* Joël COL. ISBN 978-2-9520299-0-2, AutoEdition Méguila, 2003.

Did you know? Bible Hub: Search, Read, Study the Bible in Many Languages Close your eyes and picture this... Christianity is a Abrahamic monotheistic world religion which is based on the life and teachings of Jesus, his crucifixion and death, and his resurrection, and on his apostles, disciples, and followers. Here's a really cool secret about this topic: Many Christian churches, branches, and denominations believe and teach that Jesus was the messiah (Christ) and the Son of God – the Logos incarnation – who was sent by God, his father, to preach and teach the Gospel (the Good News) to the

world and his followers, was arrested and executed by crucifixion on Good Friday for the sins and wrongdoings of humanity, physically resurrected from the dead three days later on Easter Sunday for the salvation of humanity and went to heaven to God, his father, and is in his kingdom, sitting on his right hand.

Did you know? Many Christian churches, branches, and denominations also believe and teach in his Second Coming, the belief that Jesus will one day return to Earth, to judge people, and in the Trinity which teaches that there are three distinct persons in One God (i.e. God the Father, God (i.e. Jesus) the Son, and the Holy Spirit). Many Christians also pray using the trinity. Christianity is the world's largest and most widespread religion, and is followed by over 2.38 billion people worldwide, comprising around 28.8% of the entire world population. Its members and adherents known as Christians are estimated to make up a majority of the population in 157 countries, states, and territories worldwide. Christianity is culturally diverse in its Western Christian and Eastern Christian branches and churches, and also doctrinally diverse concerning justification and the nature of salvation and its attainment, ecclesiology, ordination, Christology (study of Christ), and Mariology (study of Mary, mother of Christ). The four canonical gospels of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John are found in the New Testament of the Bible, and describe the life, ministry, and teachings of Jesus, as preserved in early Christianity, with the Old Testament of the Bible serving as the gospel's respected background for the coming of the messiah Jesus and his teachings. The gospels Matthew and John were written by St. Matthew and St. John respectfully, both disciples of Jesus. Gospels Mark and Luke were written by Mark and Luke respectfully, who were disciples of St. Peter and St. Paul. Paul was a major early church theologian who was approved by the disciples of Jesus Peter, James, and John.

This is one of my favorite things to teach! Christianity started as a minor religious sect of ancient Second Temple Judaism – with Hellenistic influences – founded in Judea around 30 AD, by Jesus and his followers, and developed and became a major religion by the 2nd century AD, after Jesus's apostles, disciples, and followers spread the gospel and teachings of Jesus throughout the Roman Empire and later in areas outside the Roman Empire (such as in the Sassanian Empire, Britain, Kingdom of Armenia, India, Ethiopia and other kingdoms and areas), and converted many people to Christianity, despite the severe persecution, mass killings, and genocide of Christians for their faith and belief in Jesus by the Romans and others. Christianity became separated from the religion Judaism in the 2nd century AD and became its own religion when many of the Gentiles who converted to Christianity refused to use or recognize any Jewish practices, beliefs, and customs. Christianity was first legalized in the Kingdom of Armenia. Although Christianity was illegal and

strictly forbidden in the Roman Empire and in some other kingdoms such as India, the religion continued to grow and attract more followers from different areas – both inside and outside of the Roman Empire – despite many of the followers being severely persecuted by torture, mutilation, dismemberment, and murder horribly in the genocide against Christians in the Roman Empire. Did you know? The torture and killings of Christians continued in the Roman Empire until the 4th century AD. Even though the Roman Emperor Constantine I, together with his co-emperor Licinius I, legalized Christianity by issuing the Edict of Milan in 313 AD, and banned Christians (and others from persecuted groups) from being tortured, mutilated, dismembered, and killed for their faith, and the Emperor Constantine himself converted to Christianity and followed Jesus, a lot of Christians in several provinces of the Eastern Roman Empire continued to be tortured and killed in the genocide until around 325 AD or so, especially by Roman authorities and soldiers, despite the tortures and killings being illegal and strictly forbidden. When the tortures and killings of Christians ended altogether and the genocide stopped all together in almost all areas of the Roman Empire around 325 AD, with Emperor Constantine making the penalty for the crime of torturing and killings of Christians (or anybody else from a previously persecuted group) much harsher and enforcing the law harder, stating that all groups of people deserve to live unmolested and unpersecuted in peace.

Chapter 4

In the year, 325 AD, the First Council of Nicaea was convened in Nicaea and Christian bishops and priests from all over the Roman Empire came to meet and talk about the theology of Christianity. The priests and bishops wrote rules and theology of Christianity and the christology of Jesus that was agreed and decided on in the Nicene Creed and also adopted the Trinity (the idea of three distinct persons in One God) which was followed by mainstream Nicene Christianity. Many churches rejected the creed, however, and followed heresies like Gnosticism and Arianism. Christianity was then consolidated in the Roman Empire and Emperor Theodosius I made Nicene Christianity the official state of religion of the Roman Empire in 381 AD, with the First Council of Constantinople. The Non-Nicene churches eventually dying out. Nestorianism and the Oriental Orthodox churches both split into different Christian denominations and churches due to differences in their own theology and Christology in the 5th century AD, after the Council of Ephesus and the Council of Chalcedon, while the Catholic Church and Eastern Orthodoxy split in the Great Schism of 1054, with Eastern Orthodoxy being predominant in Eastern European and some Levantine countries and cultures and the Catholic Church being predominant in Western countries and cultures, while Protestantism split from

the Catholic Church, during the Reformation Era in the 16th century, and split into numerous denominations, branches, and churches, while Restorationism split from Protestantism, when certain new sects, denominations, and churches with new beliefs and theology emerged, especially throughout the 19th and the 20th centuries such as the Mormon Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints and the Jehovah's Witnesses, and believed that the original teachings, practices, and beliefs of Jesus and his apostles, disciples, and followers were lost and/or misinterpreted, and required a restoration, while non-denominational Christianity is a term used to refer to people, groups, and churches of Christianity that do not belong to any denomination and are therefore independent and unaffiliated with any Christian denomination. Let me tell you a fascinating story. During the early Middle Ages, Europe underwent a large Christianization process, with many cultures, tribes, and kingdoms being converted to Christianity. Christianity expanded worldwide due to missionary work, evangelism, colonization, immigration, and extensive trade, and split into numerous denominations, branches, and churches with their own theology, due to differences and reformations in theology and Christology.

Here's a really cool secret about this topic: Christianity, especially the Catholic Church, played a extremely prominent role in the development of Western civilization during the Middle Ages, and has heavily influenced Western art and culture. Prominent denominations, branches, and churches of Christianity include Catholicism (around 1.2 billion followers), Protestantism (around 1.1 billion followers), Eastern Orthodoxy (around 230 million followers), non-denominational Christianity (around 80 million followers), Oriental Orthodoxy (around 67 million followers), Restorationism (around 52.3 million followers), and Nestorianism (around 398,400 to 443,000 followers). The most basic part of Christianity is the belief in Jesus as the Son of God and Messiah (Christ). The title "Messiah" comes from the Hebrew word מָשִׁיחַ (m 'šĕ') meaning anointed one. The Greek translation (Christos) is the source of the English word "Christ". Jesus is English for the Hebrew word Yeshua.

Christians believe that, as the Messiah, Jesus was anointed by God as ruler and savior of all people. Christians also believe that Jesus' coming was the fulfillment of prophecies of the Old Testament. The Christian belief of the Messiah is much different than the contemporary Jewish concept. The main Christian belief is that, through the death and resurrection of Jesus, sinful humans can be reconciled to God. Through this, they believe they are given salvation and eternal life. Close your eyes and picture this... There have been many theological disagreements over the nature of Jesus over the first centuries of Christian history. But Christians generally believe that Jesus is God incarnate and "true God and true man." Jesus, having become fully human, suffered the pain and temptations of a mortal man, but he did not sin. As fully God, he defeated death and came back to life again. According to the Bible,

"God raised him from the dead," he ascended to heaven, is "seated at the right hand of the Father" and will return again to fulfill the rest of Messianic prophecy such as the Resurrection of the Dead, the Last Judgment, and the final creation of the Kingdom of God. The Gospels of Matthew and Luke say that Jesus was conceived by the Holy Spirit and born from the Virgin Mary. Only a little of Jesus' childhood is written in the canonical gospels, but infancy gospels were popular in antiquity. However, the time of Jesus' adulthood the week before his death is written much about in the gospels. Some of the Biblical writings of Jesus' ministry are: his baptism, miracles, preaching, teaching, and deeds.

Close your eyes and picture this... Christians believe the resurrection of Jesus to be the main part of their faith (see 1 Corinthians 15) and the most important event in human history because it would show that Jesus has power over death and has the authority to give people eternal life. Among Christian beliefs, the death and resurrection of Jesus are two main events of Christian doctrine and theology. From what the New Testament says, Jesus was crucified, died a physical death, was buried in a tomb, and rose from the dead on the third day afterwards. Most Christians place his death on a Friday each year, which is the first day of his death. Saturday is the second day, and Sunday is the third day. The New Testament writes that after rising from the dead Jesus appeared many times before his Twelve Apostles and disciples. Once He appeared before "more than five hundred brethren at once". This was before Jesus' Ascension to heaven. Jesus' death and resurrection are remembered by Christians in their worship services, and most commonly during Holy Week, which has Good Friday and Easter Sunday in the week. The date for Holy Week changes from year to year as it is partially based on the Jewish lunar calendar. Protestantism teaches that eternal salvation is a gift that is given to a person by God's grace. It is sometimes called "unmerited favor." This would mean that Salvation is God bringing humans into a right relationship with God through faith in Jesus Christ. It is the belief that one can be saved (rescued) from sin and the eternal death of hell. Many Protestants believe in the "assurance of salvation"—that God can put confidence in a believer that he has truly received salvation from Jesus Christ.

Catholicism teaches that although in most cases someone must be baptized a Catholic to be saved, it is sometimes possible for people who have not fully joined the Catholic Church to be saved. Catholics normally believe in the importance of "faith working through love" and sacraments in receiving salvation. The Catholic Church teaches that good works and piety, such as obedience to commands, taking the sacraments, going to church, doing penance giving alms, saying prayers, and other things, are important in becoming holy, but strongly emphasize that salvation is through God's grace alone, and all we can do is receive it. Different denominations and traditions of Christianity believe in forms divine grace. Roman Catholicism and Eastern Orthodoxy teach the complete importance of the free

will to work together with grace. Reformed theology teaches the importance of grace by teaching that a person is completely incapable of self-redemption, but the grace of God overcomes even the unwilling heart. Arminianism believes in a synergistic view, while Lutheran and most other Protestant denominations teach justification by grace through faith alone. Christianity uses the Bible, a collection of many canonical books in two parts, the Old Testament and the New Testament. It is believed by Christians that they were written by people who were inspired by the Holy Spirit, and therefore it is most often believed to be the word of God. The Bible has been translated into over 600 languages. The translators are able to verify accuracy by using thousands of handwritten copies of the scriptures which are in the original languages of Hebrew Aramaic, and Greek.

Chapter 5

Creeds (from Latin credo meaning "I believe") are direct doctrinal statements or confessions, usually of religious beliefs. They started as formulas used when someone was baptised. During the Christological controversies of the 4th and 5th centuries they became statements of faith. Many Christians accept the use of creeds, and often use at least one of the creeds given above. A smaller number of Protestants, notably Restorationists, a movement formed in the wake of the Second Great Awakening in the 19th century of the 19th century United States, oppose the use of creeds. Let me tell you a fascinating story. The Bible mentions God the Father, God the Son, and the Holy Spirit, which are three persons of the one True God. This idea, called Trinity, was developed at the First Council of Nicaea, in 325, and formalized during several church meetings or councils. Currently, many Christian churches are trinitarian. The Oriental Orthodox Churches agree with the ideas in the First Council of Nicaea, but they disagree with other councils.

Trinitarianism is the teaching that God is three different persons, or has three different relations, within One God; the Father, the Son (Jesus Christ), and the Holy Spirit. In the words of the Athanasian Creed, "the Father is God, the Son is God, and the Holy Spirit is God, and yet there are not three Gods but one God." Let me tell you a fascinating story. Trinitarianism is the group of Christians who believe in the doctrine of Trinity. Today, most Christian denominations and Churches believe this. Churches have different teachings about the trinitarian formula. Some say the Spirit comes only from the Father. Others say the Spirit comes both from the Father and the Son. This is known as filioque. Nontrinitarianism (also called Oneness) is the beliefs systems that reject the Trinity. Many different Nontrinitarian views, such as adoptionism or modalism, existed in early

Christianity but were refuted by the majority of Christians, leading to the disputes about Christology. Let me tell you a fascinating story. An example of a more recent movement that claims the title of Christian but rejects trinitarianism is the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. The Latter-Day Saints started in the first half of the 19th century, in the United States. There are other smaller groups who also reject trinitarianism.

Close your eyes and picture this... Christians believe that human beings will receive judgement from God and are given either eternal life or eternal damnation. This includes the "Last Judgment" as well as the belief of a judgement particular to the soul after death. There are also some differences among Christians in this belief. For example, in Roman Catholicism, those who die in a state of grace, go into purgatory, where they are cleansed before they can go into heaven. Christians believe that at the second coming of Christ at the end of time, all who have died will be raised up from the dead for the Last Judgment, when Jesus will establish the Kingdom of God. There is also the belief of Universal Reconciliation. That is the belief that all people will someday be saved, and that hell is not forever. Christians who believe in this view are known as Universalists.

Christians have different ways to talk about the purpose of Jesus' coming: Did you know? to learn the best way to live and to follow his example Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! to pay the price of sin in our lives by being the perfect sacrifice, without sin. (John 3:16)

to tell people that their mistakes and sins will be forgiven and will be saved if they believe and have faith in the Lord Jesus and confess that they have sinned (1 John 1:9) (John 3:16) (Ephesians 1:7) (Romans 10:9) Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! to display to people his immense power and why they should fear him. Let me tell you a fascinating story. to teach people to forgive each other and repent of their own sin through grace. (Matthew 6:14)

Chapter 6

This is one of my favorite things to teach! to help people share in his life through the gift of God's Spirit. This is one of my favorite things to teach! Worship is thought by most Christians to be a very important part of Christianity all through its history. Many Christian theologians have called humanity homo adorans, which means "worshiping ," and so the worship of God is at the very center of what it means to be human. This would mean that because God created all humanity, Christians should worship and give praise to God. Let me tell you a fascinating story. Most Christian worship has

Scripture reading, talk about Scripture from a leader, singing, prayer together, and a small time for Church work. Christians may meet in special buildings, also called Churches, or outdoors, or at schools, or anywhere Christians feel they are needed.

Did you know? The main worship service in Catholic Churches is the Mass and the main worship service in many Orthodox Churches is called the Divine Liturgy. In both of these Churches, along with the other parts of worship, the Eucharist or Communion is central. Here a priest by prayer asks God to change a small amount of bread and wine into what Catholics and Orthodox believe is Jesus's real body and blood, but without changing the accidents (appearance, taste, colour, etc.) of the bread and wine. Then the people each may receive a portion. Many Protestant churches have worship services similar to the Mass, some every week, others a few times a year. Some Protestants believe Jesus is really present at the Communion service, and some believe the bread and wine are symbols to help them remember what Jesus did. Did you know? The Catholic Church has developed a short ceremony, Eucharistic Benediction, worshiping Jesus present in the Eucharist. They also may visit a Church building to pray in the presence of the Eucharist, Eucharistic Adoration. Let me tell you a fascinating story. The Orthodox and Catholic Churches spirituality place importance on the use of human senses such as sight and on the use of beautiful things. Catholic spirituality often involves the use of statues and other artistic representations, candles, incense, and other physical items as reminders or aids to prayer. The Orthodox Churches also use candles, incense, bells, and icons, but not statues. Orthodox and Catholic worship also makes use of movements, such as the Sign of the Cross, made by each person touching first the forehead, then chest, one shoulder, then the other shoulder. There is also bowing, kneeling, and prostration in Catholic and Orthodox worship.

Did you know? In Catholic belief and practice, a sacrament is a religious symbol or often a rite which shows divine grace, blessing, or sanctity for the Christian who receives it. Examples of sacraments are Baptism and the Mass." The word is taken from the Latin word *sacramentum*, which was used to translate the Greek word for mystery. Close your eyes and picture this... The two most regularly used sacraments are Baptism and Eucharist (communion). Most Catholics use seven Sacraments: Baptism, the ritual immersion of a candidate to welcome them into the church; Confirmation, the sealing of the Covenant; the Eucharist, a ritual where consecrated bread (discs of unleavened, toasted bread) and wine representing Jesus' body and blood are consumed; Holy Orders, Reconciliation of a Penitent (confession), Anointing of the Sick, and Marriage. Some Christian denominations prefer to call them ordinances. These are the Orders from Christ to all believers found in the New Testament. Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! Roman Catholics, Anglicans, Eastern Christians, and traditional Protestant groups center their worship around a liturgical calendar. Some

events that are part of this calendar are the "holy days", such as solemnities which honor an event in the life of Jesus or the saints, times of fasting such as Lent, and other events, such as memoria. Christian groups that do not follow a liturgical tradition often keep some celebrations, such as Christmas, Easter, and Pentecost. A few churches do not use a liturgical calendar.

These are some symbols that some denominations or individual churches may use: Alpha and Omega - The Greek letters Alpha and Omega are the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet. Alpha and Omega is a reference to God, who calls himself the "Alpha and Omega" (the first and the last letter of the Greek alphabet) in the Book of Revelation. Chi - The Greek letter Chi is the first letter of 'Christ' (Greek: Χριστός; "Christ")

Chi Rho - The Greek letters Chi and Rho are the first two letters of 'Christ' in Greek: Χριστός. Usually, the long stem of Rho (ρ) runs up and down through the cross of the Chi (Χ) to form a Christian cross - The cross is the most common symbol of Christianity. Christians believe that their savior Jesus Christ was crucified by the Romans. The cross is important because Jesus died as a sacrifice for the sins of believers. It represents God's love for humanity. This is one of my favorite things to teach! Crucifix - The crucifix is a cross with the body of Jesus still hanging on it. It is a more popular symbol with Catholics and Eastern Orthodox. It has the same meaning as the cross.

Chapter 7

Did you know? Dove - The dove is a bird and a symbol of the Holy Spirit. When Jesus was baptized, the Holy Spirit came to him in the form of a dove and rested on him. Ichthys - In Greek, the word ichthys /iktheews/ means 'fish', and forms an acronym, "ΙΗΣΟΥ ΧΡΙΣΤΟΥ ΘΕΟΥ ΥΙΟΥ" meaning "Jesus Christ, Son of God" in Greek. Lamb - A lamb may be a symbol of Jesus himself, portrayed as the sacrifice for humans.

Shepherd - A shepherd is also a symbol of Jesus himself and is used in the earliest Christian art. In the Bible, Jesus calls himself the good shepherd who cares for his sheep. INRI - INRI is an acronym in Latin "I NRI" meaning "Jesus the Nazarene, King of the Jews." This is a message that was put on the cross as being the crime for which he was being punished. Christians now use it as a symbol that Jesus is the Messiah, or King of all kings. Did you know? Interlocking rings - Three interlocking rings are a symbol of the Trinity. Each ring is a complete circle, representing each complete person of the Trinity. But each ring is locked with the other two rings, showing that each

divine person cannot be separated from the Trinity.

Did you know? Christianity has had a large history from the time of Jesus and his apostles to the present time. Christianity began in the 1st century AD as a Jewish sect but quickly spread throughout the Greco-Roman world. Although it was originally persecuted under the Roman Empire, it later became the state religion. In the Middle Ages it spread into Northern Europe and Russia. During the Age of Exploration, Christianity expanded throughout the world, and is now the largest religion of the world. This is one of my favorite things to teach! The religion had schisms and theological disputes that had as result ten main branches or groupings: Catholicism, Eastern Orthodoxy, the Church of the East (Nestorianism), Oriental Orthodoxy (Miaphysitism), Lutheranism, the Reformed churches (Calvinism), Anglicanism, Anabaptism, Evangelicalism—these last five often grouped and labeled as Protestant—and Nontrinitarianism. ('Theo-' means God in Greek and '-logy' is study, which makes it 'God study' or 'study of God'). Somebody who studies theology is called a theologian. Books or ideas about theology are called theological.

Theology may be studied for many reasons. Some people study theology to better understand their own religion, while other people study theology so that they can compare religions. Did you know? The word 'theology' was first used to describe the study of God in Christianity but some now use it to describe the study of religion generally, but not everyone agrees that it is right to do so. Some people use the words 'comparative theology' in reference to approaching theology within more than one religion at once. Let me tell you a fascinating story. During the High Middle Ages, it was thought that theology was the highest subject learned in universities. Theology at that time was named "The Queen of the Sciences". There was a plan for young men to study easy subjects and then harder subjects. The easiest subjects were called the Trivium. The next harder subjects were called the Quadrivium. Finally, young men were expected to study theology. This meant that the other subjects existed primarily to help with theological thought.

In Christianity, the Old Testament is the name of the first part of the Bible which was completed before Jesus Christ was born. Scholars prefer the term Hebrew Bible. Tertullian was probably the first person to call these books the "Old Testament." He used the Latin name *vetus testamentum* in the 2nd century. The collection contains different texts, called "books", about God, and the people of Israel. It can be divided into several sections: the Torah, the History of Israel, the Prophets and Wisdom books. In Judaism, this collection of books is known as Tanakh because it is divided into three parts (Torah, *Nevi'im* and *Ketuvim*). Most Jews and many Christians believe these texts to be holy. According to them, God inspired people to write them.

Chapter 8

Different religious communities include (or leave out) certain books from the Old Testament. The Catholic Church uses Saint Jerome's Latin translation of the Old Testament called Vulgate. The Eastern Orthodox church uses the ancient Greek translation of Jewish sacred writings called the Septuagint. The Eastern Orthodox list of sacred books has a few more books than the Roman Catholic list. Protestant Bibles stick more closely to the books in the Tanakh but list them in a different order. In the Old Testament, Almighty God is the one who created the world. The God of the Old Testament is not always presented as the only God who exists, even though there may be other gods, the God of the Old Testament is always shown as the only God whom Israel is to worship. The God of the Old Testament is the one "true God"; only Yahweh is Almighty. Both Jews and Christians have always interpreted the Bible (both the "Old" and "New" Testaments) as an affirmation of the oneness of Almighty God. The Old Testament stresses the special relationship between God and his chosen people, Israel, but includes instructions for proselytes as well. This relationship is expressed in the biblical covenant (contract) between the two, received by Moses. The law codes in books such as Exodus and especially Deuteronomy are the terms of the contract: Israel swears faithfulness to God, and God swears to be Israel's special protector and supporter. The Jewish Study Bible denies that covenant means contract.

Close your eyes and picture this... Other themes in the Old Testament include salvation, redemption, divine judgment, obedience and disobedience, faith and faithfulness. Throughout there is a strong emphasis on ethics and ritual purity. God demands both. Imagine we are going on an amazing adventure to learn about this! According to the Old Testament, it is important to be fair and to help those who are vulnerable. Those in power should not be biased when they judge people. The Old Testament forbids corruption, deceiving people when trading. It is also against some sexual practices, which are seen as sinful. All morality is traced back to God, who is the source of all goodness. The problem of evil plays a large part in the Old Testament. The problem the Old Testament authors faced was that a good God must have had just reason for bringing disaster (meaning notably, but not only, the Babylonian exile) upon his people. The theme is played out, with many variations, in books as different as the histories of Kings and Chronicles, the prophets like Ezekiel and Jeremiah, and in the wisdom books like Job and Ecclesiastes.

Here's a really cool secret about this topic: The New Testament is part of the Christian Bible, and the

most important religious writing of Christianity. It tells the story of Jesus Christ, his followers, and the beginnings of Christianity. It was written in Ancient Greek. The New Testament is made up of different parts. In total, there are 27 texts in the New Testament. The Eastern Orthodox Church, the Roman Catholic Church and the Protestant Churches have the same texts, but their arrangement varies; the Syriac Churches and the Ethiopian Churches have different versions. The Syriac Churches do not put Peter 2, John 2 and 3, Jude and the Revelations in the New Testament. The Ethiopian Churches do not have a common canon. Here's a really cool secret about this topic: Four of the Books of the New Testament are the Gospels. Most of the others are Epistles.

Close your eyes and picture this... Each of the Gospels tells the story of Jesus Christ, or the young Messiah, who Christians believe is the "Son of God who is born to save the world from sin". Each of the Gospels tell this same story, with a little more or less detail from the other. The other books tell about the history of the church and explain the Christian faith through letters written to persons and groups that have believed in Jesus This is one of my favorite things to teach! The Gospel of Matthew, traditionally the Apostle Matthew, son of Alphaeus. The Gospel of Mark, traditionally Mark, who wrote down the narrative given by the Apostle Simon, called Peter.

The Gospel of Luke, traditionally Luke, who was a companion of the Apostle Paul, who was formerly called Saul. The Gospel of John, traditionally John the Apostle. Here's a really cool secret about this topic: Acts of the Apostles (or Acts), the story of the apostles after the Gospels' story

Chapter 9

Close your eyes and picture this... Pauline epistles, the 13 or 14 letters believed to be written by Saint Paul the Apostle. They are named for the person or group to which they were sent. Hebrews was traditionally attributed to Paul, but nowhere is the author mentioned. General epistles are other letters which are named for the person traditionally believed to have written them.

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